

STEVE: Welcome, everyone, to the third live broadcast of our Mindfulness Meditation Teacher Certification Program. My name is Steve. I'm a producer at Sounds True, and I'll be your host for this evening. Tonight, Kristin Neff is broadcasting live from Austin, while I and the Sounds True team are all here in our Boulder studios.

Kristin is an associate professor at the University of Texas, Austin and is the author of Self-Compassion. She has been practicing Buddhist meditation since 1979 and has co-created a program on mindful self-compassion with her associate, Chris Germer, at Harvard University. She and her family were featured in the recent documentary, The Horse Boy. Welcome, Kristin.

KRISTIN NEFF: [CHUCKLES] Welcome, Steve-- so nice to be here. Just a correction-- not since 1979-- I was a young girl. 1999. [INAUDIBLE]

STEVE: Oh, sorry about that.

KRISTIN NEFF: She looks good for 70.

[CHUCKLING]

That's all right.

STEVE: Well, we're going to hand the floor over to you here and allow you to take it away.

KRISTIN NEFF: OK, great. Yeah, so what I thought I'd do is just talk a little bit about how I conceptualized self-compassion, a little bit of the research I've done on it, and then some things to keep in mind when you teach people about the concept of self-compassion. So just to say, I obviously didn't come up with the concept. Self-compassion is a central tenet of Buddhist psychology. And I learned about it when I first started practicing Buddhism back in 1999.

And in fact, I had signed up for a meditation course because my life was basically a mess. I was under a lot of stress. I had just gotten out of a divorce, and I thought, "OK, I need to learn how to deal with my stress. I'll learn mindfulness meditation."

But really, to my surprise, the woman teaching the course talked a lot about self-compassion, about how if we're a kind, supportive friend to ourselves, and we care for ourselves when we're

struggling, that we can really help ourselves through difficult times. And it was exactly what I needed to hear at the moment. And I actually started practicing this way of being with myself. And I just saw the effects that it had on my life almost immediately.

So then I started an academic career and got the job as an assistant professor back then at UT Austin. And I decided I wanted to research self-compassion because therapists had talked about it. People like Carl Rogers talked about it. People had written about it from a Buddhist perspective.

But at that point, no one had actually done any scientific research on it. And at that point, of course, a lot of research was being done on mindfulness. And I thought, "Well, if people can research mindfulness, why can't we research self-compassion?"

So my first task when I decided I wanted to research this is I knew I had to come up with a very clear operational definition, something that was clear so that I could actually create a measure to actually assess how self-compassionate people were. So although people had talked about self-compassion, no one had really clearly laid out, this is exactly what we mean by self-compassion. So where I started, in terms of thinking about how to define self-compassion, was actually, "How do people define compassion for others?"

So I'm showing here-- hopefully you can see it too-- this slide of a homeless woman. And it's really, I think, useful to think about what goes into the experience of compassion for others. Because from my point of view, really, compassion for self and others is the same. It's just that we more readily give compassion to others than to ourselves.

So let's say you're walking down the street, and there's this homeless woman at the side of the street. Now, let's face it. Some days we have compassion for her, and some days we may not have compassion for her. So let's think about what needs to go into the experience of compassion for her. [CLEARING THROAT] Excuse me.

The first thing, of course, is we have to notice her. Right? If you walk on by, sending your text messaging, and you don't notice this woman by the side of the road, you can't have compassion for her. But more than that, you have to notice something about her. And that is her suffering. Right? In order to have compassion, we have to be willing to take in the fact that this woman's suffering. You know? She probably has a hard life. Is she getting the help she needs? What's her situation?

And the reality is we often don't want to take in suffering. As we know, and as you know-- I'm sure you've been learning all about this-- our natural tendency when suffering arises is to push it

away, to avoid it. So really the first step of having compassion for this woman is mindfulness. We have to be willing to open to and be aware, without resistance, the fact that there is suffering present.

So that's the first step. But the second step, of course, is how do we respond to her. So you may notice she's suffering, but maybe you just have a judgmental reaction. That's not compassion, right? In order for it to be a compassionate response, we have to have a sense of care and kindness, a friendliness for that woman. So that kind of differentiates a compassionate response from a judgmental response.

And so I was thinking about this, but then I realized, what's the difference between compassion and pity? So we all love to get compassion from people, but we hate to be pitied. And I was really interested in distinguishing self-compassion from self-pity. And, of course, I realized that what distinguishes compassion from pity is that sense of common humanity. You know, "There but for the grace of God go I."

So if you look down on that woman or feel sorry for her, that's pity. But if you look at her and say, wow, wonder how her life led her to this point. That could be me in a different situation. That's compassion. So it's really about thinking about what goes into compassion for others that I came up with, you see, a little Venn diagram here, Neff's three-component model of self-compassion.

From my point of view, you really need all three elements, all of these three foundational elements, in order to qualify as self-compassion. So that's mindfulness, kindness, and a sense of common humanity. So again, let's start with the mindfulness. And you might think that in temporal sequence, whenever self-compassion arises-- and I would say the same for compassion for others-- the mindfulness always has to come first. Because if there's not awareness of suffering, you can't even have the compassionate response.

So with ourselves, it means we are able to be with our feelings as they are. We're able to kind of admit the we're in pain instead of avoiding it. But we also have to not run away with our feelings of pain, right?

So what happens with self-compassion is instead of saying, "Oh, this is terrible. It's the worst thing in the world," we have some balance with it. Yes, I'm suffering. I'm taking that in. But we aren't lost in the storyline of the suffering, which is a process I call over-identification. You can see my Buddhist roots here, right? So that's the first step in self-compassion-- is we need to be mindful of our pain without running away with it or getting carried away with it.

And then the second bit is this kind response, right? So again, when we notice we're suffering, and especially if that suffering is coming from a failure or feeling inadequate in some way, we need to have an understanding response to ourselves-- treating ourselves the same way we would treat a good friend we cared about.

And it's interesting-- I teach a lot of self-compassion-- if you ask people how they treat themselves when they're having a hard time or fail to make a mistake versus how they treat their friends, most people treat themselves radically differently. So the idea with self-compassion is we give ourselves the same kindness we would give to others we cared about. We're soothing and comforting.

But it's not just the soft qualities of soothing and comforting. There's also an active element to self-compassion, which means supporting and protecting oneself. Sometimes self-compassion means say no-- that's harmful. So I'm not going to do that or I'm not going to let you do that.

And so, by the way, there's also a motivational element to self-compassion. Some people define compassion as being moved by the suffering of another and being motivated to do something about it-- so the same with self-compassion. Again, not only are we kind in response to our own suffering, we feel motivated to help ourselves.

And from my point of view-- and now this could be debated-- but from my point of view, I see any moment of pain as worthy of a compassionate response. So sometimes when we're suffering, people think of big suffering. I'm just talking about any moment of emotional pain or discomfort.

So for instance, you stub your toe. If you respond with anger and irritation because you think it's a small thing, well, then, you might kick your cat or kick your dog. Whereas, if you have a kind, compassionate response, it helps process even that small amount of pain in a healthier way.

And then, finally, the third component of common humanity is really, really important for distinguishing self-compassion from self-pity. So basically, all I'm talking about when I refer to common humanity is the idea, the acknowledgment that the human experience is imperfect, that all people lead imperfect lives, and all people make mistakes. All people are flawed. This is what it means to be human.

Now, of course, we know this logically. Right? If I were to ask anyone who is watching this right now, do you know anyone in this entire world who is perfect or lives a perfect life? He'd say, no, of course not. But what happens irrationally, and it's very useful to catch these moments in yourself or help other people catch these moments, is when we fail or we make a mistake-- we

get that call from the doctor or something really difficult happens-- our immediate assumption is that something has gone wrong.

OK. This all happens at the unconscious level. There is this idea that this is not supposed to be happening. As if what's supposed to be happening is I am not making mistakes. I'm not screwing up. This difficult thing isn't happening. And when that's not the case, something has gone wrong.

And that feeling that something has gone wrong actually tends to make us feel very isolated from fellow human beings. Like, somehow, in that moment, it feels like it's just me who's failed, or it's just me who's struggling with the issue. And actually one of the most damaging-- and my research kind of shows this. One of the most damaging aspects of not having self-compassion is this tremendous feeling of isolation.

So really, if you think about it, one of the beautiful things about self-compassion is when we remember, when we connect to the fact that suffering is shared and we aren't alone in this-- it's part of the human experience-- we can turn any moment of suffering into a moment of connection. OK. So again, from my point of view, you need all these elements to really count as a compassionate response.

And it's also-- I just want to take a moment to tell you about the underlying physiology of compassion. Actually, both the lack of self-compassion, self-criticism, and self-compassion have a different physiology. OK. So hopefully you're at the slide that shows this lion attacking the zebra.

So what we know is that when we criticize ourselves, what we're actually doing is we're tapping into the body's threat defense system. This is the oldest part of the brain. Sometimes it's called the reptilian brain. It's our quickest, most easily-triggered reaction. When there's a threat, our amygdala gets triggered. We get ready for a fight, flight, or freeze, and adrenaline is released, et cetera.

So the system was designed to deal with physical threats, right? When a lion's chasing us. But actually, these days, most of the threats are not to our physical self. The threats are to our self-concept. So when we fail, or we make a mistake, or we get rejected, or something difficult happens in our life, we react as if our very lives were threatened.

As you know, we kind of confuse our self, our actual self, with our beliefs and concept of ourselves. And our body reacts the same way. So what happens when we feel threatened--

when we fail or make a mistake for instance-- is we naturally want to solve the problem. So how do we do that? We go into fight, flight, or freeze.

So we fight the problem. No. Unfortunately, the problem is ourself because we failed in some way. So we criticize ourselves. We actually attack ourselves to help ourselves feel safe and to try to make the problem go away. OK. So self-criticism is associated with a lot of adrenaline and cortisol release-- a lot of stress. But it's useful to remember that when people are criticizing themselves, what they're actually doing is trying to help themselves feel safe because they feel threatened in some way.

The flight response-- that kind of feeling isolated, separate from anyone else. What's happening is we're turning that flight response inward. We're wanting to isolate ourselves from everyone else because we don't feel safe, again. Or the freeze response-- that manifests often as rumination. We get stuck on, "I'm so bad. I'm so terrible," or, "This problem's so bad." As if, somehow, when we think about it for the 57th time, the problem's going to go away. When we get stuck in these negative thoughts, that's a freeze response.

So all of these things are a natural response to threat. They're way to help ourselves feel safe. We think it will help us feel safe. It also helps us-- we think we're trying to control the situation, but of course, the reality is it just makes things worse. So luckily, as human beings, we are not just reptiles with our threat-defense response. We also have another response, another way to feel safe, and that is the mammalian caregiving system.

So what we know is that when we give ourselves compassion, when we give others or ourselves compassion-- things are pretty much the same either direction-- what we're doing is we're tapping into the caregiving system. A lot of names for this-- sometimes people refer to it as the attachment system.

So basically, if you think about it, the big evolutionary advance from reptiles to mammals is that when reptiles are born-- let's say the mommy lizard lays eggs. There's no caretaking. They just hatch on their own. The mommy lizard might even chomp a few if she's hungry and needs a snack. Mammals are very different.

Mammalian young are born very immature. They have a very long developmental period, which allows their brain to have a long time to adapt successfully to the environment. Mammals are very adaptable because they're born so immature and they have this long developmental period. Actually, human beings have, by far, the longest period of development before they're ready to leave home. It takes between 15 and 30 years for the human mammal to be mature enough to leave the home. I'm sure some of you can relate to what I'm saying here.

But basically, that's one of the reasons humans are so adaptable is because we're born so mature. We've got this long period of growth. And so a system had to evolve that would basically do two things. It would prompt the infant to want to be safe and close to the caregiver-- so not to wander off into the wild. And similarly, it would prompt the caregiver to want to take care of the infant. So human beings have a very strong, well-developed caregiving attachment system.

So what this means is when we give ourselves compassion, we are actually tapping in to our own body's compassion system. We're releasing things like oxytocin and opiates. We're helping ourselves feel safe when we give ourselves this care-- that maybe it was designed to be received from our parents, but we can also give the same care to ourselves.

And that's why in a lot of my work, I really help people find some sort of soothing touch or some physical gesture of compassion or care. Because we know that the compassion system is triggered by two key things-- gentle touch and gentle vocalizations. The quality, the tone of your voice, actually also triggers this compassion response.

Just think of a mother kitten-- a mother cat licking her kittens and purring and meowing, and they're all cuddled up together. We are actually the same way. So when we use a gentle, kind tone of voice and we give ourselves some sort of support of touch, it's actually a really good way to access that compassionate response.

So you guys are training to be teachers. And I'm sure the question of self-compassion will come up. And you might even mention it-- that self-compassion is a good thing to try out. And you should know that whenever you mention the word self-compassion, people have big blocks to self-compassion. Our culture doesn't encourage it. And people have documented that people have a fear of self-compassion. They think all these awful things will happen to themselves if they're compassionate and give up their self-criticism.

So I just want to go to the next slide, which briefly shows what are the five major common misgivings about self-compassion. Now, I've talked about self-compassion to hundreds of crowds all over the world. And they usually just throw it out to the audience-- do you have any misgivings about self-compassion? These same five always crop up. It's actually amazing.

So one is people are afraid it's a form of self-pity. Right? That if they're self-compassionate, they're going to have a pity party. No one likes someone who's having a pity party. People think that it's weak. This is actually a big thing for males, especially. It also is a problem for females,

but a lot of males do not like the idea of self-compassion at all because it feels soft, and they're afraid it will make them weak. So people think it's weak.

The number one, actually-- empirically, the number one fear of self-compassion is it will undermine your motivation. If you're compassionate to yourself, then you'll get soft, and you'll lose your drive. You won't achieve your goals. Right?

Another fear is that it will lead to self-indulgence. It's kind of related to the motivation, but it more takes the form of self-compassion just means being nice to yourself, giving yourself pleasure, doing whatever you want. Again, we know that's not healthy. And then, the last fear that comes up often is that it takes two forms-- either that it's really selfish. It's self-centered. It's self-absorbed. Or even the worst form of this is that it's narcissistic. OK.

So when I first started talking about self-compassion, which was, gosh, about 15 years ago, whenever I talked to crowds, these misgivings would always come up. And I would have these really elaborate, great, philosophical and logical reasons why you don't have to worry about these things. Now, the good news is we have data that shows that all of these misgivings are actually misconceptions. In other words, there's hard empirical data to show that all these fears of self-compassion are false.

So just I put together this little graph that just shows how much research is being done on self-compassion. Some of you may have seen similar graphs with research on mindfulness, about five or ten years ago. Self-compassion is following a similar trajectory.

So back in 2003, I published the first article, defining it operationally, defining self-compassion, and I created a scale to measure it. And for several years, I did a couple of things, and it was just basically my work. And then people started catching on to it, and it started taking off. And now, there are well over-- this is even outdated. There are over 1,200 empirical journal articles examining the benefits of self-compassion. I can't even keep up with the literature.

So the good news is this is no longer just a nice idea. We actually have empirical evidence to show that it works. OK. Just to say, and this is something you should know, I did create a scale to measure self-compassion. If anyone wants to take the scale, if you're working with someone who's interested in understanding the level of self-compassion, you can go to my website, self-compassion.org, and you can take the scale online.

But basically, what I did way back when is I just tried to create a very valid, self-report measure describing the behaviors associated either with the presence of self-compassion or the lack

thereof. The scale has been used in thousands of studies now. And basically, and also just to say, most of the research is done with the scale, but it's really starting to change, which is great.

Now, people are getting very clever, doing experimental methodologies, looking at what happens if you put people in a self-compassionate mood. How does it change their behavior? And so basically, what we know is that, as I said, all the misconceptions or misgivings people have about self-compassion are false.

So for instance, I'm just going to very briefly describe them because you may be challenged about self-compassion at some point. Self-compassion-- does it lead to self-pity? No. What is self-pity? It's self-focus. It's rumination. It's kind of catastrophizing-- my life is terrible. I'm terrible.

What happens with self-compassion is there's less rumination, right? And that's with the mindfulness gives us. We aren't stuck in our thoughts. We aren't just absorbed by our thoughts. With this self-focus, we're able to step outside of ourselves and see ourself clearly. And also, the common humanity part means it's not so self-focused.

Is it weak? All I can say is, well, there was one study we did of veterans coming back from Iraq and Afghanistan. And what we discovered was their level of self-compassion was more predictive of whether or not they developed PTSD the next year than the level of combat exposure they faced. So think about this. What this is saying is no matter how much combat they saw, what was more important for predicting how well they dealt with it was, could they be an inner ally to themselves, or were they an inner enemy.

And that's really what self-compassion is. When you have self-compassion, you're friend to yourself. You're an ally. You aren't cutting yourself down, belittling yourself, and pulling the rug out from underneath yourself through this treating yourself meanly.

And so actually, what we know-- there's a lot of research. When you think of veterans, people going through divorce, people dealing with major health issues-- self-compassion is a huge source of strength and resilience. It's a very important coping mechanism. It gives us strength. It doesn't make us weak at all.

What about the idea that self-compassion is going to undermine your motivation, make you complacent? Once again, it's just the opposite. Really, I think there's a lot of research on this. Because I have a feeling a lot of other researchers didn't quite believe it. [CHUCKLES] Yeah, surely that one isn't true. Surely, if we take a bunch of students and help them be self-compassionate, they won't be as motivated to succeed. They're actually more motivated.

Just to give an example, there was a study at UC Berkeley. And they gave students one of those tests, vocabulary tests, that's impossible to succeed in. It seems like it should be easy, but it's actually really, really hard, and everyone fails.

And so half the students, they helped to be self-compassionate about the failure. They helped them be mindful of what happened, be aware of their feelings of frustration, be kind to themselves, be a good friend to themselves, and just remember that failure is part of life. It's part of the human experience. So half the people they helped be self-compassionate.

The other half of students, they just said, "Hey, don't worry about it. You must be smart. You got into Berkeley. Right?" They gave them a little self-esteem boost. And what they found is that the people who are helped to be self-compassionate about the failure-- they gave the students a second vocabulary test and said we're going to test you again. "Why don't you go ahead and study for this test?" And they measured how long and how hard the students studied. And they studied longer and harder if they were self-compassionate than if they were just given a self-esteem boost.

So basically, what self-compassion does is, first of all, reduces fear of failure because it's safe to fail. Because if you fail, you're going to have your own back. You're still going to be kind to yourself. So if you're a failure, we know, it really gets in the way of motivation. And when you do fail, it doesn't derail you. You're more likely to be able to learn from your experiences, pick yourself up, and try again and keep trying.

So again, this is just one study. But a lot of research showing self-compassion increases motivation. Is it self-indulgent, which is another fear people have? Again, just the opposite. What we find is that self-compassion actually encourages people to take good care of themselves.

The example that I like to use with this: Would a compassionate mother tell her child to eat all the sweets he or she wants and to skip school? No, of course not. We know that as a compassionate parent, you want what's best for your child, and you're going to choose healthy behaviors over short-term pleasure.

The exact same thing happens with self-compassion. Self-compassionate people go to the doctor more often. They exercise more. They eat healthier. So self-compassion does not lead to self-indulgence.

And the final one-- I hope I'm not overkilling on the research here, but you can tell that I get very excited by it. Self-compassion is not selfish. In fact, it leads to more giving and caring relationship behavior.

So again, just to give a little example, we did a study. We looked at 100 couples. And we had each couple fill out the self-compassion scale but then had their partner rate, how does this person treat you in your relationship. And what we found is that self-compassionate people were described as being much more caring, much more capable of intimacy, much kinder, less controlling, granted a lot more freedom in the relationship, and they got angry less often.

And there's lots of research like this, showing that self-compassion actually helps people give to others. So what's going on here? Well, if you think about it, when you are in a compassionate state of mind, when you have mindfulness, when you are feeling connected to others, and when you're kind, you actually have more resources to give to others.

When you're in a self-critical frame of mind, when you're just thinking about how terrible I am, and you're locked in this sense of, "I'm so horrible, and it's just me," and you're feeling all isolated, you don't have resources to give to others. So being self-compassionate actually gives you the resources to give to others. OK.

So that's misgivings. And again, if you'll just indulge my-- I just want to just mention, very briefly, a little bit of some of the other research we find. Self-compassion is strongly linked to well-being. So people with more self-compassion, they're much less likely to be anxious or depressed or to try to commit suicide or have problems like disordered eating. Right? So it's very good for reducing negative states of mind.

And it's also linked to enhanced positive states of mind-- things like more life satisfaction, more happiness, more optimism. And I just want to say why I think this is the case. There's something really special about self-compassion in that it's kind of unusual for a state to be so strongly linked to reductions in negative states of mind and increases in positive states of mind.

And the reason I think that happens with self-compassion-- and so I'm going to give you another way to describe my three components. So if you're talking to people about self-compassion, this is a way to help evoke what it feels like, as opposed to its conceptual definition.

The state of self-compassion-- when you are in a state of self-compassion, you are in a state of loving, connected presence. Right? The presence is the mindfulness. The connectedness is the common humanity. The loving is the kindness. So when you are in a state of self-compassion, again, you are in a state of loving, connected presence.

And often, I tell our teachers, when you want to embody self-compassion, it's much easier just to think of-- embody being in a state of loving, connected presence. So what happens when you throw pain at loving, connected presence?

First of all, it can hold it. It's a resource for holding the pain without being overwhelmed. It helps heal the pain. But more than this, loving, connected presence is actually a positive emotion. It feels good to be in a state of loving, connected presence.

So what you're doing with self-compassion is you're generating this beautiful positive-mind state in which to hold the negative emotions without pushing them away, without trying to get rid of them, but just to hold them, to be there with yourself in a state of loving, connected presence when things are difficult. And that's, I think, what helps reduce the negative states of mind and increase the positive states of mind. OK.

So I'm just going to just talk about a few more points. A lot of people are really excited about self-compassion because, you know, "Can self-compassion be taught?" Absolutely. [CHUCKLES] Right? I don't even really do basic research on the benefits of self-compassion anymore because I'm much more interested in, "How do we teach people to be more self-compassionate?"

And so now, that's my main focus of my work. And a lot of people are asking, "Is this just a personality trait, or are some people just born more self-compassionate than others?" Well, actually, it is. Some people are born more self-compassionate than others. And obviously, people who are raised with loving, connected, caring parents tend to be more self-compassionate than parents who criticize them all the time.

So we come by our self-compassion levels-- honestly, a lot of it's our genetics. A lot of it's our early family history. But at the same time, self-compassion can be learned. So for instance, one of the things we know is that mindfulness increases self-compassion. OK.

So just the very act of being able to, again, turn toward pain, to not resist it, to not run away with it, but to be present with it, with courage and this sense of acceptance, which also usually spills over to acceptance of ourself-- mindfulness alone increases self-compassion. And we know that programs like in MBSR, MBCT, some of these mindfulness-based therapy programs-- one of the reasons they work is because it increases self-compassion.

And so what we know from the research is for some people-- and, actually, we suspect this in the research. It's too much to say we know, but we suspect. For some people, just learning the skill of mindfulness-- of being in a friendly, loving way with your experience-- that's enough for self-compassion to arise.

Some people, though, need it to be a little more explicit. So a program like MBSR-- the self-compassion tends to be more embodied in the teacher's tone of voice, embodied in their loving, connected presence, embodied in little gentle instructions. "Oh, don't be too hard on yourself." Just kind of give yourself gentle encouragement. And that's enough for a lot of people.

But what Chris Germer and I, my colleague-- we wanted to create a program that explicitly taught skills of self-compassion, where we have actual practices, actual things you can do, meditations focused explicitly on developing the skill of self-compassion. So we've created this eight-week training program called Mindful Self-Compassion.

In a way, we didn't need the term "mindful" in there because it's one of the three components of self-compassion, but we wanted it there because, obviously, we wanted to emphasize that our program is very closely related-- it's a sister program-- to all the mindfulness-based programs out there. So we created this program, and we've been working on it for about 10 years now. We're about to come out with a manual, professional manual, for the program, a workbook. And I think it's in pretty good shape if I say so myself.

And basically, we know through research that the program works. So we did one study-- a randomized, controlled trial-- and found that people who took the program-- compared to a control group, not only did they increase in self-compassion and mindfulness, which you would expect, they also increased in compassion for others and all sorts of well-being variables, so things like increased happiness and life satisfaction-- decreased depression, anxiety, and stress.

And what was really cool is that we tested them one year later and all skills were maintained. And they didn't have any drop in self-compassion level. And this is, personally, I think, the benefit of explicit training.

So if your self-compassion comes more implicitly, maybe from the warmth of the teacher or being more gentle with yourself, that's helpful, but it's more likely to fade over time. Whereas, if you give people explicit self-compassion practices, things they can actually do, it does seem to be a skill that can be maintained, long after the warm glow of the teacher in the class is gone.

And just to make one point, we've also created an adapted version of this program for teens called Making Friends with Yourself. If anyone wants to read more about these programs, you can find links from my website.

OK. So we've got a little bit of time left. I just want to bring a couple other points up for you all because you're training to be teachers. So if you're like me, you're probably really excited about self-compassion, and you can see its benefits, and you want people to learn to be more self-compassionate. You need to know a couple things.

First of all, a lot of people, believe it or not, when they start practicing self-compassion, they actually have a negative reaction to it. They tend to resist self-compassion. You might think that, well, why would anyone resist this beautiful state of mind of loving, connected presence? But you'll find you'll encounter a lot of resistance to it when you start helping people to be self-compassionate.

And in fact, Chris Germer, who's a therapist, came up with a great term for this resistance. And he calls it "backdraft." OK. So what is backdraft? Backdraft is a firefighting term. And basically, it refers to the fact-- what happens when a fire crew gets to a burning building. And if the house is on fire, they don't just reopen the doors of the building because if they do that, the air rushes in, it feeds the fire, and the flames rush out. And it can be really quite explosive. So instead, what they do is they kind of poke little holes all around the house to let the air in slowly so you don't have this explosive reaction.

Well, if you think about it, most of us-- what we've done with the flames and fire of our own suffering is we've closed our hearts. We had to to survive, and especially people with a trauma history. They really had to close the door of their heart to survive.

So what happens when you teach someone to be self-compassionate, and maybe they put their hands on their heart or start being kind to themselves, the fresh air of the compassion rushes in, and the flames of the old pain rush out. And it can be kind of like a kaboom-- kaboom. It can be really quite explosive. You have to be aware of this because it will happen.

Fortunately-- I wish Chris was here. He loves to say, "Don't worry. Eventually kaboom becomes kab-o-o-o-m." [CHUCKLES] In other words, backdraft is nothing to be afraid of. It's actually a good sign. OK. So basically, what's happening with when we give ourselves compassion is when we give ourselves unconditional love, immediately, all the memories of the ways in which you've been unloved come up, and they come out. All the wounds, all the old pain, it just starts releasing.

Now, this pain has to be contacted in order for it to heal. Right? If we just keep it shoved down in our souls and in our hearts, it will never heal. So self-compassion and backdraft is actually a sign that the healing process has begun.

But at the same time, we need to be compassionate in terms of how we practice self-compassion. We don't want to be overwhelmed. And the people we're teaching-- we don't want them to be overwhelmed. So the first thing you should do is, whenever I talk to people about self-compassion, I always tell them about backdraft. So they don't think that they're doing it wrong if they feel bad when they try to give themselves kindness.

You just say, hey, this is good. It's just a sign that the healing process has begun. I think the metaphor is really useful. People understand, "Oh, I'm having backdraft." Sometimes just labeling what you're experiencing, which is actually a mindfulness practice, is enough to just say, "Oh, OK. I see it's backdraft. I don't have to worry about it."

On the other hand, sometimes it's stronger than that, and you want to give people tools not to overwhelm themselves. So basically, what happens, you might say, when backdraft is occurring is you want to go to straight mindfulness without the added components of the kindness and the love. So if you think of mindfulness as awareness of what's happening, and the compassion is the love that accompanies that awareness, especially love towards one's self, what we know is that the affection part of it, the love part of it, can be activating for some people and can cause this backdraft reaction.

And that's why just basic mindfulness practices like going to your breath or feeling the soles of your feet, taking a walk-- so in other words, you're distracting your attention from the reaction, but you're still being present-- is a very good way to deal with backdraft. And if that doesn't work, however, you can practice compassion in other ways.

You can pet your cat. You can have a cup of tea. You can take a warm bath. People need to know that if they're at any point feeling overwhelmed by compassion, that it's an act of compassion to close down, to pull back; to say, "It's a bit too much for me--" I'm not going to do this practice right now.

But if they do it consciously, not as an unconscious just reaction-- I just can't handle it-- but as a conscious, I'm feeling overwhelmed-- I need to take care of myself. I need to stop. Then believe it or not, what they are actually doing is they're building the muscle of self-compassion. And by building that habit of giving themselves what they need, then they actually can then come back to giving themselves a little more of what they need and a little more of what they need. Go slowly, just like poking those little holes in the house that's on fire, letting the air in slowly, and eventually they can get through it.

We've actually been really amazed because we always tell-- anytime we start a self-compassion training program, we always tell people that they can close down when they need to, that they need to take care of themselves. If, at any point, they feel overly activated by the compassion, they should feel free to distract themselves but, again, to do it with conscious awareness. What we found is that people who do it, they can really take care of themselves if they have a name for it and they've got a few practices to deal with it.

OK. And then in my remaining time, I just want to bring up another issue which is probably on many people's minds. And that is, "Well, what's the difference between mindfulness and self-compassion?" So I've kind of been alluding to it. In a way, mindfulness is part of self-compassion, but compassion has these other elements of kindness and common humanity.

But it's more than just that. And I want to show you a little slide. OK. If you think about what mindfulness is, mindful awareness-- mindful awareness is aimed at experience. Right? It's experience with pain, experience with happiness, an experience of eating raisin. But it's always aimed at experience. And it does have this accepting quality to the experience. In other words, if you don't like the raisin, instead of spitting it out, if you're one of those people who had to do the raisin-eating exercises in your mindfulness training, you just say, "Mm, unpleasant." Right?

So you're aware of what's happening, and you don't resist it. But you don't have compassion for an experience. You don't have compassion for the raisin. Compassion is always aimed at the experiencer, a sentient being who's having an experience. So this is one difference. Mindfulness is aimed at the experience. You're aware of what's happening in your experience. Compassion is aimed at the experiencer in a particular context. And that is when that experience is painful.

What defines compassion-- if there's no suffering present, it may be lovingkindness for instance. But if it's compassion, it means that suffering is present. So compassion is aimed at the person having the pain, and it's aimed at holding, soothing, comforting, caring for the person who is having the experience.

Now, sometimes when people, especially long-term mindfulness practitioners-- they start practicing self-compassion, and they feel like it's kind of messing with things. Because mindfulness is just about opening. That's why I have the picture of the opening hand-- open hand-- opening to what is. But compassion is caring for yourself, soothing yourself, comforting for yourself, being there for yourself.

And it feels like that with compassion, you're maybe trying to manipulate things. And in fact, you have to be careful because most people, when they first start practicing compassion, will use it to try to make the pain go away. And so we always tell people, when we teach self-compassion, that there's a paradox. And this is the paradox. In a moment of struggle, we give ourselves compassion not to feel better but because we feel bad.

So in other words, it's very natural when people first learn self-compassion-- they put their hands on their heart, or they say something kind to themselves and their pain subsides. Pretty soon, they will start using the self-compassion to make the pain go away. And when you do that, that's just a [INAUDIBLE] form of resistance, and it won't work.

But we don't have to use compassion to make the pain go away. We can just be with ourselves, with great kindness and care, while we're also accepting the fact that it's very hard right now. And the reason we can do that is because the mindfulness is aimed at the experience-- what's happening. Compassion is aimed at the experiencer.

So in other words, I can say to myself, I am so sorry you're hurting so much right now, darling. I call myself darling. It seems to work for me. So when I do that-- I'm so sorry that you're hurting so much, darling-- I'm fully accepting, with mindfulness, that the pain is here. At the same time, I'm responsive. I care. I'm concerned. Is there anything I can do to help? And that's aimed at the experiencer.

And of course, with compassion, you will take action, if you can-- you can't always-- to make the unfolding of future moments better, if possible. But right now, right here, it sucks. And part of compassion is owning this sucks, and, oh, I'm so sorry-- I'm here for you. OK.

And so I like to say that mindfulness is necessary to self-compassion, but self-compassion actually really enhances mindfulness. Why? Because it gives us that sense of safety. When we hold ourselves, when we comfort ourselves, when we care for ourselves with kindness-- and again, we're activating our own care-giving system-- we feel safe. It really helps people mindfully open to their pain.

There's actually a recent study-- some of you may be interested-- that showed that when they taught people learning mindfulness meditation a bit of self-compassion first, they were more likely to stick with their mindfulness practice. Often what happens is people start practicing mindfulness-- they aren't very good at it. They criticize themselves, or they get frustrated, or they're mindful of pain, and they can't handle it, and they give up.

So self-compassion creates a sense of safety needed to mindfully open to your pain. And so I like to think of mindfulness and compassion as a tango. At some level, it's just the tango. You can't even separate them. They're just doing this beautiful dance together, and it naturally arises.

But when you're learning or you're teaching mindfulness and compassion, I find that it's kind of helpful to know who's playing what role. Because each role of each dancer is slightly different. So again, mindfulness is aimed at accepting experience. Compassion is aimed soothing, comforting, and caring for the experiencer.

OK. I think I did it. And I still have 10 minutes left for questions. [CHUCKLES] So anyway, I hope that wasn't too fast. I'm going to send you all notes from my presentation. So if you didn't get it all, you'll have it in your notes. And here's also just some websites if you want to find out more.

OK. So have you been working hard, taking people's questions?

STEVE: I have. We've got some fantastic questions. And before we get into them, I wanted to let people know, we're going to find a way to get them those notes. I'm not quite sure what that will be, but we'll find a way to get you Kristin's notes so you have everything to be determined here.

OK. So great questions coming in-- you ended helping us to understand the difference between mindfulness and self-compassion, but a question that came in early on is how is self-compassion different from lovingkindness. Can you please give an example so that we can be able to teach the difference to our students?

KRISTIN NEFF: Yes, so compassion and lovingkindness are kind of two sides of the same coin. There's a meditation teacher who likes to say, when the sunshine of lovingkindness meets the tears of suffering, the rainbow of compassion appears.

So basically, lovingkindness is just a general, open-hearted, caring, friendly attitude. But you can feel lovingkindness toward someone when they're happy. And in fact, for those of you with a Buddhist background, when loving meets someone else's joy and you feel joy with them, it manifests as what's called Mudita, sympathetic joy. When it's just kind of general lovingkindness general goodwill, it manifests as lovingkindness.

But when lovingkindness meets suffering and stays loving, then it manifests as compassion. And that's not necessarily always the case that it stays loving, right? Because when we get into

contact with pain, our natural instinct is to avoid it and resist it because we don't like pain. So what happens, if we can stay loving, if we can keep our heart open, it manifests as compassion.

And it actually feels different. We teach an exercise in a course where we let people feel the difference between loving kindness and compassion. Lovingkindness is more of a happier feeling. It's kind of a positive feeling. Compassion is bittersweet. It's tinged with sadness because you're really opening to sorrow. And it feels different although you might say it's root, open heart, is the same. Yeah.

STEVE: Kristin, we're getting a lot of questions coming in about adjusting the language of self-compassion. Some of them are when working in a business setting, when working with a audience who would be less receptive. Another question-- you mentioned teens and your work with teens. So what are some ways that these aspiring teachers can learn to shift that language?

KRISTIN NEFF: Yes, great question because, as I said, a lot of people have an aversion to self-compassion. You say the word, and it triggers them. And they have all these misgivings. And so the UT Longhorn men's basketball team-- the coach had read my book and liked it and wanted me to come in and talk to his players about self-compassion.

And I knew that talking about self-compassion probably wouldn't go very well. So I never used the word once. You can use words like inner support, being a good friend to yourself, inner strength, resilience, because all these are other ways of describing what compassion does. When you're compassionate toward yourself, you're supporting, caring, being there for yourself in a very helpful way.

So like in business context, something like being a supportive inner coach might work, or finding inner strength, or just a courageous way of being with your difficulty. Words like that-- you can tailor it for your audience. Or just being a good friend to yourself-- it's funny. That one seems to-- most people kind of get that. It also gives them a point of reference.

If you just ask people how do you treat your friends when they're suffering or going through a hard time, and then how do you treat yourself, and they can kind of see the difference, you don't actually have to use the word self-compassion. Friendliness, supportiveness, good coach-- all those things do just as well.

STEVE: We're going to touch on backdraft here in a pedagogical question on backdraft. What are some ways that we can help people to poke small holes with self-compassion to lessen the possibility of backdraft?

KRISTIN NEFF: Yeah. So basically, the way Chris and I deal with it is we always talk about this process of opening and closing. It's like we tell people, your hand's on the faucet. You can decide how much you're going to open your heart. And when it feels overwhelming, you can actually close down. You can distract yourself. You can leave. You can think of your grocery list.

And so what happens is people-- really the poking the small hole is the new habit of trying to be a good friend to themselves, trying to give themselves what they need. And so like I said, the beauty of this is when people decide this is overwhelming-- "I can't handle it. I'm going to think of my laundry list-- or grocery list." They're actually practicing self-compassion in that moment. They have just poked a little hole.

So telling people they can go as deep or as shallow as they want-- it doesn't really matter. What matters is just this habit you're building of learning to give yourself what you need. And so you can also adjust things. Like, we teach soothing touch. And for a lot of people, they love having their hands on their heart.

But other people, maybe they had an abusive history. They put their hands on their heart, and it just feels terrifying. So you can just do something smaller, like maybe touch your hand. Or maybe don't touch yourself at all. Take a warm bath. Pet your cat. You give people a lot of options to know how to take care of themselves.

But it's really, really, I find, really important to tell people that it's natural and normal that this is happening, and that it's a good sign, and they don't need to be afraid of it. And they've got their hand on the faucet. They can choose how much to let in.

Just to say, another metaphor you can use-- if the backdraft metaphor is too explosive, which it is-- you can also use the metaphor of what happens when you're shoveling snow outside, and your hands get numb, and you can't really feel the cold anymore. And then you get back inside the warm house. And as your hands warm up, they start to hurt.

That's another metaphor for backdraft. We've numbed ourselves because we couldn't handle the pain. When we start to warm up our relationship, it starts to hurt. But it's temporary and it will pass. So as long as people know that, they seem to be able to get through it. They really need to know it doesn't mean they're doing it wrong. It actually means they're doing it right. Yeah.

STEVE: Kristin, in the middle of your lecture, you shared the five common misgivings about learning self-compassion. So this question says, "Let's assume someone is completely on

board. What do you find are the things that people most frequently misunderstand about self-compassion?"

KRISTIN NEFF: Yeah, well, I don't know if this is a misunderstanding or this is just a tendency of the human mind, but everyone who learns self-compassion will try to use it to make the pain go away. Of course. First time you put your hand on your heart and you feel so much better, then the next time, you're going to put your hand on your heart to make the pain go away. What could be more natural?

But so what people-- it takes a while to really get used to the idea that what self-compassion is doing is being with the pain in a kind, supportive way, as opposed to making the pain go away or fixing the problem. So that will definitely come up even if people are on board.

You can misuse anything. I mean, some people actually might try to misuse self-compassion as self-indulgence. From my point of view, it's not really self-compassion if you aren't meeting your long-term needs. But they might say, "Eh, well, I'm going to be self-compassionate. I'll skip work today." Something like that.

So it definitely can be misused. And the human mind is just the human mind. It's not really a problem. But yeah, it will be misused like everything [CHUCKLES] else in life. Yeah.

STEVE: OK, so our last question tonight before time runs out here-- you mentioned that your program with Chris Germer and that in it there are the explicit skills-- clearly, we don't have much time left to go too deeply into them. But the question is, "Can you share some of those explicit skills so we can start thinking about them?"

KRISTIN NEFF: Yeah. Well, so really, luckily, I've got a lot on my website. So if you go to my website-- just Google self-compassion and you'll find it. For instance, I've got a recording, "The Self-Compassion Break," which is one of the most easy portable skills, where you basically combine soothing touch with just words designed to evoke the three components of self-compassion: mindfulness (this is hard), kindness (saying something nice to yourself), and common humanity-- this is part of life.

That's on there. I've got a lot of meditations that are designed to bring self-compassion to ourselves. So that's really, I'd say, a good place to start. I don't really have time to teach anything. But we have (I think) 26 concrete, explicit self-compassion practices in the Mindful Self-Compassion program.

And like I said, we're coming out, actually, with Sounds True, with our own online course very soon. So if you're interested, it's eight one-hour sessions. You can take that. You can read the workbook and the manual soon. So the information is out there. But Chris and I have worked pretty hard, and I think we're pretty happy with what we've put together. It's definitely a teachable skill. Yeah.

STEVE: Excellent. Well, Kristin, thank you so much for being with us and bringing your rich depth of experience into the conversation that we're all on. Thank you.

KRISTIN NEFF: Yeah, you're welcome. Like you say, and I'm so happy for all the viewers, that they're getting the guidance of Jack and Tara, you lucky buggers. [CHUCKLES] I wish I had taken this course when I was first starting this journey. Anyway--

STEVE: Excellent. Well, again, thank you so much. And with that, we'll conclude our third live broadcast of our Mindfulness Meditation Teacher Certification Program. Thank you to everybody out there who is with us tonight. It's such a rich community.

It's lovely to connect this way on a month-to-month basis. And we're looking forward to actually seeing you quite soon here, in our second intensive retreat. So we hope that you join us for our next live session on September 5, at 5:00 PM Eastern Time. For Sounds True, this is Steve. Thanks again for being with us.